

Wasting Time?

On the temporal rhythms of TikTok

Introduction: Why TikTok?

- Short video app; available since 2017; around 800 million active users
- Negative and patronising reporting on the app; image of it being an ultimate 'time-wasting machine' (e.g. Odell 2019)
- Case to understand discourses of the 'good life' and 'modern boredom' in relation to digital media use

Introduction: the For You Page

- TikTok as a way to escape an experientially grey 'here and now' and social media landscape
- Brokers sensibility for present structure of feeling (Williams 1977), personalised but collective
- Engagement with other 'ordinary strangers' inaccessible because of lockdown or on other social media platforms

Affect 1: The 'tired body'

- Use of TikTok after work and before falling asleep
- Bridge between work and leisure time
- Sense of 'ontological security' (Giddens 1991, Silverstone 1994)
- Food metaphors: TikTok helps to digest the day

Affect 2: The 'waiting body'

- Boredom as the experience of being left empty by a situation or space
- TikTok as response to situational boredom, e.g. waiting
- TikTok as response sustained boredom, e.g. lockdown
- TikTok becomes meaningful only once integrated into rhythms of everyday life

Affect 3: The 'energised body'

- More general stimulation and awareness that life still goes on
- Concrete inspiration for crafts, recipes, workout, etc.
- Neoliberal imperatives of productivity and justification of the app
- Pressure for TikTok to be something more than just a 'feel good space'

Conclusion: Taking digital culture seriously

- Developing situated and de-naturalised understandings of the 'good life' and where it can unfold.
- Seeing digital technology not just a source of but also as solutions to modern malaise.
- Attending to 'feel good spaces' not just once they have become of relevance for being more than that, e.g. as public spheres.

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